

WHAT IS AN ICON?

SESSION 00.3 HANDOUT

NAME _____ DATE _____

♦ MEMORY VERSE — COPY BY HAND

The Apostle Paul wrote this about Christ. It is the deepest reason the Orthodox Church paints icons of Him — because He is the visible image of the invisible God. Copy the verse below twice in your best handwriting.

Christ is the image of the invisible God, the firstborn of all creation. — Colossians 1:15

♦ VOCABULARY — MATCH EACH WORD TO ITS MEANING

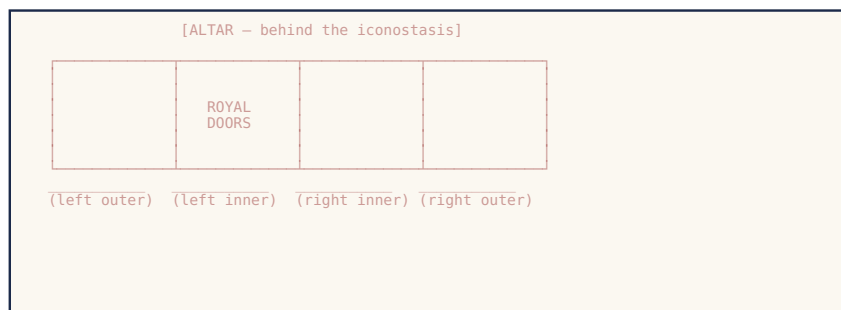
Draw a line from each word on the left to its meaning on the right.

ICON	•	• The Greek word for <i>bowing down</i> — the honor we give to icons, the Cross, and the saints. It is not worship.
VENERATION	•	• The screen of icons in front of the altar in every Orthodox church. The Royal Doors are at its center.
ICONOSTASIS	•	• An image of Christ, the Theotokos, or a saint — written, not just painted — that is a window into the Kingdom of God.
THEOTOKOS	•	• Greek for <i>God-bearer</i> — the woman who gave birth to God, Mary the Mother of Christ.

♦ LAYOUT — LABEL THE ICONOSTASIS

The screen of icons in front of the altar is called the **iconostasis**. Four large icons sit on the iconostasis in nearly every Orthodox church in the world. Label each position below using the word bank.

Word bank: *Christ · Theotokos · St. John the Forerunner · Patron Saint of the Parish*



Outer left: _____ Inner left: _____

Inner right: _____ Outer right: _____

✦ SKETCH — DRAW THE LETTERS YOU'LL SEE ON EVERY ICON OF CHRIST AND THE THEOTOKOS

In the boxes below, draw the abbreviations you'll find on icons of Christ and the Theotokos. Look at any icon at SJTD this Sunday — these letters are there.

ICON OF CHRIST



IC XC = Iesous Christos (Jesus Christ in Greek)

Practice writing each abbreviation three times below.

IC XC: _____

MP ΘY: _____

ICON OF THE THEOTOKOS



MP ΘY = Mētēr Theou (Mother of God in Greek)

✦ REFLECTION — WRITE 3 TO 5 SENTENCES

The lesson said an icon is a **window**, not a picture. A picture is something you look *at*. An icon is something you look *through*. The saint on the other side is looking back at you. This week you stood in front of one icon at SJTD for a full minute. Write 3 to 5 sentences: which saint did you choose? What did it feel like to be looked at by an icon? Did anything happen that surprised you? *It's okay if nothing dramatic happened. The icon was still looking back.*
